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Should revolutionary violence be considered morally justifiable when used to overthrow  
oppressive systems?

Throughout history, many unfortunate situations have arisen in which innocent people are deprived of their basic human rights. When faced with the choice between freedom and oppression, these individuals may feel compelled to take steps they would otherwise deem excessive. From the French Revolution to the Russian Revolution 115 years later, individuals who are mistreated and oppressed decide to take up violence as a means of freeing themselves. That choice brings about the question today: should revolutionary violence be considered a morally justifiable way of overthrowing systems? While some historians believe that violence is not justifiable under any circumstances because it is still the intentional infliction of harm against another, there is more evidence to argue that revolutionary violence can be morally justifiable, so long as it brings about peace for a greater part of society.

A leading example that historians reference that depicts revolutionary violence being morally justifiable is the French Revolution. In the late 1780s, the third estate in France, made up of the 98% of France's commoners, was taxed heavily. Meanwhile, the first and second estates, each making up only 1% percent of the population as clergy and nobility, were taxed far less and lived far more luxurious lifestyles. As explained by Marx and Engels approximately 45 years after the end of this revolution, "It has resolved personal worth into exchange value, and in place of the numberless infeasible chartered freedoms, has set up that single, unconscionable

freedom—Free Trade. In one word, for exploitation, veiled by religious and political illusions, it has substituted naked, shameless, direct, brutal exploitation” (7). In these situations, when confronted with the reality that you may either live under exploitation and oppression, violence becomes the only acceptable means of change. Peaceful revolution proves ineffective, as seen in the earlier years of the French Revolution when protesters who aimed for nonviolent demonstrations were repressed by King Louis XVI and his assembly. Mylonas, who wrote a PhD in French Studies, stated this as such, “For the Incorruptible violence was a necessity but not only for the survival of the revolution but for the realization of his political vision, the republic of virtue” (12). However, even with this show of effectiveness of revolutionary violence, not all historians argue this to be morally justifiable.

Historians that study both the French Revolution and the Russian Revolution argue against many of the actions that took place within these times of political change. As seen between 1793 and 1794 in France, violence took a strong hold on the revolution under the leadership of Maximilien Robespierre. Patrice Higonnet, a French historian who serves as a professor of French History at Harvard, explains this period, known as the Reign of Terror, when he says, “The tyranny of the Year II is not immanent in the Revolution itself. Terror is the effect of a Jacobin ideology that became autonomous within the Revolution” (12). Higonnet argues that much of the violence during this period, most notably this Reign of Terror, which resulted in an estimated 17,000 deaths, was not necessary for the revolution, but instead was a byproduct of the radicalization of the Jacobins. Therefore, with this violence in excess and serving no purpose other than to please the extremist political party spearheaded by Robespierre, revolutionary violence cannot be considered morally justifiable. A similar period was seen in the Russian Revolution during the Russian civil war known as the Red Terror. During this time, Russia was

under the Bolshevik regime led by Vladimir Lenin, who had only recently taken power after the overthrow of the Romanov dynasty. The oppressive tsarist regime had finally ended, and Lenin, who was at the center of the Revolution, helped to orchestrate an estimated 50,000 to 200,000 executions. Historian Mitchell Cohen states, “No regime identifying with Bolshevism has led, at any time or place, to anything that can be called ‘liberation’” (2). Although these criticisms of revolutionary violence are valid, there is more evidence to be argued to its benefit, notably on the lines of the aforementioned Bolshevism.

Bolshevism first emerged as a movement led by Vladimir Lenin in 1903, growing immensely in 1917 where it would be formally aligned with by Leon Trotsky and Joseph Stalin. Bolshevism, though deriving from the meaning “majority,” did not begin as a large movement, and was largely outpowered by the Mensheviks. However, after continued repression by the Tsar, the Bolsheviks grew to power and eventually overtook Tsar Nicholas II. While many disagree with the actions taken by Lenin, it was not something done recklessly. After the failures of peaceful demonstrations, which are explained by Chatzakou as, “In 1905 a group guided by a priest, intended to demand civil rights from the tsar but before they could reach the Winter Palace, they were shot by the police,” Lenin, though still in exile, began to develop his ideas for the future of the revolution (5). The nonviolent attempts at revolution proved unsuccessful, leaving the Russian people with no choice but to enact violence to achieve their freedom. This violence, even if subject to scrutiny over its moral justification, did prove effective, and therefore arguably justifiable, in achieving a regime change and ending the oppressive tsarist control. Tsar Nicholas II did not value the rights of the proletariat within Russia, instead only protecting the bourgeoisie. Marx and Engels, who notably played an immense role in shaping the ideology of Lenin, stated in the final section of the *Manifesto of the Communist Party*, “[We] openly declare

that [our] ends can be attained only by the forcible overthrow of all existing social conditions” (58).

As can be seen through the events that have unfolded in the years prior, revolutionary violence is an extremely effective method of overthrowing oppressive systems, and therefore, as it grants freedom to the people, it is morally justifiable. The actions of Robespierre and Lenin, though controversial, cannot be described as anything other than successful at their intention. These revolutionaries provided regime changes for the individuals of their respective countries. It is for this reason that revolutionary violence is morally justifiable. It ensures the protection and defense of the rights of the people. As the African American revolutionary Malcolm X once stated, “You don’t get freedom peacefully. Freedom is never safeguarded peacefully. Anyone who is depriving you of freedom isn’t deserving of a peaceful approach by the ones who are being deprived of their freedom.”

Works Cited

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